PATHOS WORD BANK

COMPASSION UNIT | MIDDLE SCHOOL WRITING

Pathos is a persuasive technique that appeals to readers' emotions. Use vivid descriptions, sensory details, and carefully chosen words to help readers experience what a character feels.

1 Words That Create Emotion

Sadness & Loneliness	Fear & Vulnerability	Hope & Compassion
Heartbroken	Terrified	Reassured
Abandoned	Helpless	Comforted
Isolated	Vulnerable	Cherished
Forgotten	Anxious	Relieved
Rejected	Defenseless	Appreciated
Devastated	Overwhelmed	Encouraged
Invisible	Frightened	Accepted
Miserable	Desperate	Grateful
Humiliated	Uncertain	Protected
Defeated	Trembling	Valued

2 Powerful Descriptive Phrases

Instead of Writing...	Try Writing...
She was sad.	Tears blurred her vision as she struggled to speak.
He was lonely.	The empty chairs reminded him that no one had chosen to sit beside him.
She was scared.	Her heart pounded as fear tightened its grip.
He was embarrassed.	His cheeks burned as laughter echoed around him.
She felt forgotten.	She wondered if anyone would even notice she was missing.
He was relieved.	A wave of relief washed over him as someone finally stopped to help.
She was happy.	A genuine smile spread across her face for the first time that day.
He felt loved.	For once, he knew he mattered to someone.

3 Strong Action Verbs

Trembled • Whispered • Collapsed • Clutched • Flinched • Sobbed • Stumbled • Hesitated • Comforted • Embraced • Reassured • Rescued • Shielded • Reached • Consoled

4 Sensory Details That Build Pathos

Sense	Example
Sight	Tears glistened in her eyes.
Sound	The cruel laughter echoed down the hallway.
Touch	His hands trembled against the cold pavement.
Smell	The sharp smell of antiseptic filled the room.

Taste	A salty tear reached the corner of her mouth.

5 Sentence Starters for Emotional Writing

Try one of these openings	Or try one of these
No one seemed to notice that…	A single act of kindness…
For the first time, she realized…	Imagine how it would feel to…
He desperately wished that…	What hurt the most was…
The silence felt heavier than…	Just when all hope seemed lost…
As everyone walked away, she…	Sometimes, compassion begins when…

6 Words That Encourage Compassionate Action

Empathy • Kindness • Dignity • Humanity • Mercy • Generosity • Understanding • Belonging • Selflessness • Encouragement • Responsibility • Hope • Acceptance • Respect • Compassion

Student Writing Challenge

Choose at least FIVE words or phrases from this bank to strengthen your compassion paragraph. Don't just tell the reader how a character feels—use details that help the reader feel it, too.

WEAK: The injured man was scared because no one helped him.

STRONGER: The injured man lay trembling beside the dusty road, desperately watching each approaching traveler and praying that someone would finally stop.